

CLEO PASKAL

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Ms. Cleo Paskal is Non-Resident [Senior Fellow](#) for the Indo-Pacific at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies (FDD), Washington, D.C. and [Adjunct Fellow](#), Pacific Forum, Honolulu, Hawaii.

With extensive field experience across the Indo-Pacific, Ms. Paskal's work combines ground-level knowledge and networks with strategic level applications. Her groundbreaking research on PRC political warfare operations in the Indo-Pacific has been used to shape U.S. government policies and to support the renewals of the critical Compacts of Free Association.

Ms. Paskal testified multiple times before Congress, as well before the parliaments of the United Kingdom and Canada. She regularly moderates/lectures for high-level geopolitical professional development seminars for the U.S. Military, and has taught at defense colleges in the United States, United Kingdom, India, Canada and Oman.

At FDD, apart from her own research, she has arranged for private and public events with key Indo-Pacific leaders. A recent series focused on first hand, high-level descriptions of PRC influence operations and featured public events with the President of Palau, former President of Federated States of Micronesia and the Governor of the Commonwealth of Northern Mariana Islands.

She is currently leading a multi-year research project on countering PRC political warfare in the U.S. Freely Associated States (Palau, Federated States of Micronesia, Marshall Islands).

Other projects she managed included commissioning and editing a multi-authored series on Oceania for the East-West Center in Washington D.C. and a multi-year research project based at CÉRIUM (Université de Montréal) looking at evolving geopolitics in the Indo-Pacific.

From 2006 to 2022, she was an Associate Fellow at Chatham House, London, where, among other responsibilities, she was research lead on the multi-year futures project 'Perspectives on Strategic Shifts in the Indo-Pacific 2019-2024'. This included writing the research paper [Indo-Pacific Strategies, Perceptions and Partnerships: The View from Seven Countries](#). Another component of the project involved coordinating research and planning events with think tanks in the U.S. (East-West Center D.C.), U.K. (Chatham House), France (Ifri), India (Gateway House), Tonga (Royal Oceania Institute) and Japan.

Paskal is widely published in the academic and popular press and has written for (among many others): *Naval War College Review*, *Journal of Indo-Pacific Affairs*, *The Diplomat*, *Defense News*, *Military Times*, *Washington Times*, *The Telegraph*, *The Australian*, *Japan Times*, *The World Today* and *International Affairs*. She is frequently quoted/interviewed by major media, including *Reuters*, *Newsweek*, *New York Sun*, *Fox*, *Radio Free Asia* and the *John Batchelor Show*. She is currently a columnist for *The Sunday Guardian* (India) newspaper.

Sample Work

U.S. Congressional Testimony

- [Crossroads of Competition: China in Southeast Asia and the Pacific Islands](#); U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission; March 20, 2025
- [Examining the Office of Insular Affairs' Role in Fostering Prosperity in the Pacific Territories and Addressing External Threats to Peace and Security](#); Subcommittee on Indian and Insular Affairs (Committee on Natural Resources); March 5, 2025
- [How the Compacts of Free Association Support U.S. Interests and Counter the PRC's Influence | Indo-Pacific Task Force](#); Indo-Pacific Task Force of the House Natural Resources Committee; June 14, 2023
- [Preserving U.S. Interests in the Indo-Pacific](#); Subcommittee on Indian and Insular Affairs of the House Natural Resources Committee; May 16, 2023
- [Strategic Importance of the Pacific Islands](#); House Committee on Asia, the Pacific, Central Asia, and Nonproliferation of the House Foreign Affairs Committee; October 20, 2021

United Kingdom House of Lords Testimony

- [The Implications of the Transfer of Sovereignty of the Chagos Archipelago to Mauritius](#); UK House of Lords' International Relations and Defense Committee; June 11, 2026. [Video](#).

Canada House of Commons Testimony,

- [Review of Canada's Indo-Pacific Strategy](#); Canada's House of Commons Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and International Development; April 21, 2026. [Oral testimony](#)

Sample Academic Articles

- [Urgent Need for New Approaches to Keep the Pacific Free](#); *Fletcher Security Review*; 2025
- [Protecting the Corridor of Freedom to America's Asian Border](#); *Journal of Indo-Pacific Affairs*; July 1, 2024
- [Island-Hopping with Chinese Characteristics—What the PRC Is Doing in the Pacific Islands, Why It Matters, and Why the Time Has Come to “Block and Build”](#); *Naval War College Review*; May 5, 2024
- [Chinese Influence Strategies Are Putting the Pacific Islands on the Front Line—Again](#); *2024 China Transparency Report*; The Heritage Foundation; 2024
- [From Non-Alignment to Realignment](#); *Comparative Connections*; September 15, 2023

Sample Research Projects

- Defending the U.S. Freely Associates States against Malign Influence; funded by Smith Richardson Foundation; 2022 - present.
- [Indo-Pacific Strategies, Perceptions and Partnerships: The View from Seven Countries](#); Chatham House; 2021

Sample Popular Media Articles

- [Modi Era India displays geopolitical acumen](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; June 14, 2026
- [How the UK Is Undermining US Indo-Pacific Security](#); *National Interest*; January 7, 2026 (co-authored with Alexander Gray)
- [U.S.-Palau agreement shows new National Security Strategy in action](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; December 28, 2025
- [Death of Daniel Suidani shows how China gets the better of Quad](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; October 26, 2025
- [Australia Watches as Chinese Proxies Try to Jail Opposition](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; October 19, 2025
- [Indian Re-emergence and the Foreign Policy Boom](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; September 17, 2025
- [U.S. can not afford to lose Diego Garcia](#); *Washington Times*; August 12, 2025
- [CNMI: China eyes control of America's Asian frontline](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; August 10, 2025
- [At Foreign Ministers' Meeting, China-Pacific Islands Relations Steam Ahead](#); *The Diplomat*; June 2, 2025
- [FSM breaks ground on China-led airport reconstruction project in Woleai](#); *Pacific Island Times*; May 28, 2025
- [China roils the Pacific waters courtesy Australia and New Zealand](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; February 23, 2025
- [Who's afraid of China? Palau inauguration calls bluff of 'friends to all, enemies to none'](#); *Pacific Island Times*; January 28, 2025
- [Deconstructing the Inauguration: No, not that one](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; January 26, 2025
- [Australia vies with China to turn the Solomons into a police state](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; December 29, 2024
- [Palau is under attack from PRC](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; November 2, 2024
- [Daniel Suidani's arrest in the Solomons proves CCP is scared](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; October 13, 2024
- ['Only strength can ensure peace': Palau President Whipps Jr.](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; September 22, 2024
- [China watches as the U.S. fumbles around in central Pacific](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; April 28, 2024
- [NATO Isn't Defending Guam, But Others Are](#); *The National Interest*; April 10, 2024
- [The Importance of America's Pacific Family](#); *The Diplomat*; April 3, 2024
- [In the Pacific, U.S. bureaucracy messes up against PRC influence operation](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; December 17, 2023
- [Seven ways China can benefit from the Israel-Hamas war](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; November 5, 2023
- [Northern Mariana: Time to close China's backdoor into the U.S.](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; September 3, 2023
- [U.S. fighting China on the wrong battlefield](#); *The Sunday Guardian*; July 9, 2023
- [Beijing's Subversive Political Warfare in the Pacific—and the Need for Greater Engagement by the United States and Taiwan](#); *Global Taiwan Institute*; March 22, 2023